3.5.5 Referencing URLs

There are many situations in which URLs appear inside HTML. You may be linking to another page, referencing a CSS file, or showing an image. In most of these cases, your URL will be pointing to another Django view or an asset under Django's control. You can hardcode the URL in your HTML, but if you decide to refactor your URL mapping, you'll end up with a lot of work—or worse: some broken links.

To help solve this problem, Django provides a way of naming URL mappings. Recall the `django.urls.path` objects inside urls.py that map a URL to a view. These objects have an optional argument allowing you to name the `path`. You can reference a URL in your code using this name or in a template via the `{% url %}` tag.

To see this in action, first, you will need to name one of your URLs. Open RiffMates/RiffMates/urls.py and modify the `path` object for the Credits page, adding the `name` attribute, like in the following listing.

Listing 3.4 Naming a URL mapping

```
# RiffMates/RiffMates/urls.py
...
from home import views as home_views
...
urlpatterns = [
    ...
    path('credits/', home_views.credits, name="credits"),
]
```

Naming the mapping for the credits view

By adding the `name="credits"` argument to the `path` object, this URL mapping can now be referenced with the string `"credits"` elsewhere in your code and templates. To access the resulting URL in a template, use the `{% url %}` tag, giving it `'credits'` as an argument. Note the surrounding quotes; the `{% url %}` can take either a variable or a hardcoded string. The most common use for the `{% url %}` tag is inside a link in your HTML:

```
<a href="{% url 'credits' %}">Credits Page</a>
```

The preceding anchor tag's `href` parameter gets rendered using the URL for your Credits page. If you decide to change the URL for the `credits()` view, you only do this in the urls.py file, and the `{% url %}` tag takes care of the rest.

> **Always name your routes**
>
> You should always use named URLs in your code. Doing otherwise is like not using constants in your code.

Take careful note of the use of the single and double quotes in this example. As HTML uses double quotes to demark a tag's attributes, you need to use single quotes inside the `{% url %}` tag.